

Marital Therapy

Fit to be Tied

MODERN MARRIAGES ARE NOT WHAT THEY USED TO BE. THE ENCHANTED CLICHES REQUIRE A LOT OF ADJUSTMENT TO THE DIAPERS-AND-DISHES ROUTINE.

1. PRAGMATIC TO THE CORE

They aren't scoffing at the idea of happily-ever-after, but add a few more reasons apart from love to their vow list. They choose to be together due to certain reasons—society, family, children or money. It is predominantly women who adjust to such a relationship. They set their priorities in the marriage practically, while performing their roles with utmost dedication.

2. A CONVENIENT ARRANGEMENT

Love unites them, but as the years roll by, increasing responsibilities drive them apart. Many couples feel trapped as they don't share the same equation with their spouses. Not meeting each other daily doesn't really obstruct their lives, although an unspoken wish to share more than household expenses remains. They are career oriented, independent decision makers and financially at par.

3. DOCILE DEPENDENCE

Either both or one partner is blindly dependent on the other. Such couples might seem to be made for each other, but with time they start taking each other for granted and expectations soar to unimaginable heights. The next level is evidently, possessiveness. Being completely dependent, they don't see beyond their partner and therefore regress socially.

4. GETTING EVEN

When "my way is the only way" becomes a constant state of existence, anger and resentment plague the relationship. With this outlook, communication becomes volatile often leading to verbal and physical abuse. Couples look for opportunities to get even with each other. Sex becomes a tool for settling scores. Getting along with people becomes difficult. Varkha Chulani, clinical psychologist at Lilavati Hospital, Mumbai, advises, "Couples should learn to accept the idiosyncrasies of

each other and also develop more of a you approach to life."

5. STATUS SYMBOL

Marriage is equivalent to social status, which leads to a crippled relationship. Sometimes amidst the union of two big families, which is often not less than a business merger, the purpose of marriage is forgotten and materialism takes front seat. Such marriages need more work as they can be emotionally defeating.

6. ABSENT AND INVISIBLE

Work or social activity becomes primary to a partner, leaving the other with a feeling of being married to an invisible person. These are marriages where extra marital relationships increase and children feel unwanted. Family life is affected and the invisible spouse doesn't even realise it. "The need of the hour is reduce outside time and increase together time. It might seem like a great sacrifice, but it'll help figure out what things to streamline to strengthen the bond," says Anjali Chhabria, psychiatrist and psychotherapist, Mind Temple, Mumbai.

by Purvi Malhotra

whether frequent or sparse—was seen as having something to do with the exercise of autonomy and self-control, maybe even with a sense of duty, more than with spontaneity, instinct or passion. Apparently, some men were, though others were not, prepared to adjust their coital timetables in case their wives were unenthusiastic. One young man, Ghurye recorded, "who is an MA and married for over four years, has coitus every night but is thinking of lessening the frequency to once a week. He laments that both he and his wife are unable to take to this new rule as they cannot control themselves, he more than his wife. He further regrets that owing to the habit of masturbation he has very little control over his passion. He used to get excited sometimes at the sight of a lady so much as to have discharge. This lack of control, he further regrets, has told both on his career and health." Not unexpectedly, today's surveys give no hint of the Hindu moral value of abstinence, encoded in the teacher's wavering resolve, but assume the "pleasure principle" ipso facto. For that matter, they also ignore auto-stimulation as an aspect of male or female sexual behaviour, an omission which, considering its prominence in popular sex manuals and self-help literature, is actually quite remarkable.

A big difference between then and now, from which much else flows, is the age of middle class women at marriage. In Ghurye's survey, over 17 per cent of the women were married at age 13 or below, with the average age being just 16.2 years; their husbands were more than eight years older, averaging 24.5 years. A

